

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Sales and Business Development English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Discovery and Qualification

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

03 Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

04 Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

05 Enterprise Buying Committees

Clarify missing information before responding.

06 Negotiation and Contract Redlines

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Partnerships and Channel Development

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

08 CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Discovery and Qualification

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

discovery - The process of learning needs or facts; in litigation, formal exchange of relevant information.

qualification - Documented demonstration that an item, process, or person meets defined requirements for a purpose.

pain point - A specific difficulty experienced by a customer or user.

buying process - The steps an organization follows to evaluate, approve, and make a purchase.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A demonstration needs a workflow

The lesson's prospect requests a demonstration without explaining the workflow, problem, or buying process.

01 • Account executive: Before arranging the demonstration, could you describe the workflow you want us to focus on?

02 • Prospect operations lead: We haven't shared that yet. I don't want a general tour that misses our actual problem.

03 • Account executive: Which step currently causes the most difficulty, and who experiences that pain point?

04 • Prospect operations lead: I need to consult the users before answering precisely. My initial request was exploratory.

05 • Account executive: That's useful to know. Discovery can clarify the need before we assume a particular use case fits.

06 • Prospect operations lead: Would you also need to know our buying process before showing us anything?

07 • Account executive: We can hold an exploratory discussion, but we shouldn't mistake interest in a demonstration for a qualified purchase.

08 • Prospect operations lead: Understood. I'll identify the workflow owner and ask what they want to examine.

09 • Account executive: Thank you. We can then agree a focused demonstration and clarify the decision process at an appropriate stage.

10 • Prospect operations lead: Let's start there, without treating the meeting request as a commitment to buy.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A replacement request with an unclear trigger

Separate fictional case: a prospect asks about replacing a scheduling system, but has not said whether the concern is cost, usability, or a contract event.

01 • Business development representative: You mentioned replacing your scheduling system. Could you clarify what prompted you to explore alternatives now?

02 • Prospect service manager: Different teams have concerns, but we haven't agreed which issue is the main reason for considering a change.

03 • Business development representative: Then I shouldn't assume the pain point is pricing simply because you asked for a quote.

04 • Prospect service manager: Correct. The quote helps us explore, but it won't define what a replacement needs to improve.

05 • Business development representative: Who could explain a typical scheduling problem and the effect it has on the service team?

06 • Prospect service manager: I'll involve the scheduling supervisor. They can describe actual examples rather than general dissatisfaction.

07 • Business development representative: Good. Could we also clarify whether there is a buying deadline, rather than infer one from this inquiry?

08 • Prospect service manager: There isn't a confirmed date in the information I've shared. I'll check the internal planning process.

09 • Business development representative: I'll record that as unknown and keep the next discussion focused on requirements and qualification.

10 • Prospect service manager: That works. We need clarity before we compare replacements or imply that procurement has begun.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A trial request from outside the user team

Separate fictional case: an innovation manager requests a trial for a warehouse workflow, but the warehouse owner has not participated in discovery.

01 • Account executive: Could you explain which warehouse task the proposed trial should test and who owns that workflow?

02 • Prospect innovation manager: I requested the trial, but the warehouse owner hasn't joined the discussion yet. The task is still broad.

03 • Account executive: Then we should involve that owner before treating the trial as evidence of an agreed operational need.

04 • Prospect innovation manager: Could we run it with my team first to demonstrate momentum, even without their input?

05 • Account executive: We could discuss a limited exploration, but it wouldn't validate warehouse fit unless the relevant workflow is represented.

06 • Prospect innovation manager: I understand. Interest from innovation isn't the same as qualification with the people who would use it.

07 • Account executive: Exactly. Could you arrange a conversation about the current process, pain point, and intended decision?

08 • Prospect innovation manager: I'll ask the warehouse owner to participate and confirm capacity to assess a trial.

09 • Account executive: Thank you. We can then discuss scope without assuming a purchase decision or implementation commitment.

10 • Prospect innovation manager: I'll present the next meeting as discovery, not as an approved trial launch.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Discovery and Qualification

A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

Scenario 2 | A quote request from an unknown buying role

A fictional prospect's analyst requests pricing for fifty users but has not explained the workflow, user group, or purchasing role. Hold a short discovery conversation that clarifies purpose without treating the analyst as the budget owner.

Role A: You are the account executive. Ask what the pricing will support and which workflow is in scope.

Role B: You are the prospect's analyst. Explain that you are gathering information and must confirm the user group internally.

Possible opening: Could you clarify what decision the fifty-user estimate will support and which team would use the service?

Success checks

- Distinguish an exploratory estimate from a qualified purchase.
- Clarify workflow and the contact's role without assumptions.
- Agree a focused next discovery step with unknowns recorded.

Add a complication: Your sales colleague wants to mark the opportunity qualified because a user count was supplied.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A sales slide lists product features, but the prospect wants to reduce time spent preparing monthly reports.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

value proposition - A clear explanation of the relevant benefit an offering provides to a particular customer.

use case - A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

success metric - A defined quantitative indicator tied to an intended outcome.

stakeholder - Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Features are not the prospect's outcome

The lesson's prospect wants less time spent preparing monthly reports, but the sales slide lists features.

01 • Prospect reporting manager: Your slide lists features, but I need to reduce the time we spend preparing monthly reports.

02 • Solutions consultant: You're asking about an outcome, not a feature list. We should connect a relevant use case to that goal.

03 • Prospect reporting manager: Could you explain the difference using our reporting need rather than another broad product description?

04 • Solutions consultant: A feature is something the product does; a value proposition explains how that capability could help your workflow.

05 • Prospect reporting manager: So faster report preparation is the intended benefit, but we still need evidence that it happens here.

06 • Solutions consultant: Exactly. We haven't measured your baseline or validated a time-saving result in your process.

07 • Prospect reporting manager: Then the success metric should concern preparation time using a consistent definition, not the number of features shown.

08 • Solutions consultant: Agreed. We should involve the stakeholders who perform and review monthly reporting.

09 • Prospect reporting manager: Let's clarify that workflow before using any percentage-saving claim in the proposal.

10 • Solutions consultant: I'll focus the next discussion on your use case, measurement boundaries, and what remains to be tested.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A notification is not a resolved approval

Separate fictional case: a prospect wants fewer delayed approvals; a demonstration shows automatic notifications, but no outcome test has occurred.

01 • Sales engineer: The demonstration shows an automatic notification. It doesn't yet establish that your approval delays will decrease.

02 • Prospect process owner: I assumed sending reminders was the same thing as solving the delay. What distinction should we consider?

03 • Sales engineer: A notification prompts someone; it doesn't ensure they have the information, time, or authority to approve.

04 • Prospect process owner: Then our use case needs to explain what causes the waiting, rather than count messages sent.

05 • Sales engineer: Exactly. The value proposition should connect the capability to your actual obstacle, with assumptions made explicit.

06 • Prospect process owner: Would time from a complete request to a decision be a more relevant success metric?

07 • Sales engineer: It could be, once we agree the definition and check whether the necessary data is available.

08 • Prospect process owner: We should also include the approvers, because their part of the workflow determines whether a reminder is useful.

09 • Sales engineer: Agreed. I'll avoid claiming a measured reduction until a suitable evaluation supports it.

10 • Prospect process owner: Let's assess the approval workflow first and keep the notification as a capability, not a promised outcome.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

One export button, several reporting responsibilities

Separate fictional case: a sales demo shows a one-click export; the prospect's reporting workflow also requires review and reconciliation, which have not been assessed.

01 • Prospect finance operations lead: The export takes one click. Does that mean our entire monthly reporting task becomes a one-click process?

02 • Account executive: No. The demonstration covers export only; your review and reconciliation steps have not been assessed.

03 • Prospect finance operations lead: Then the feature shortens one visible action, but the value claim needs the whole use case.

04 • Account executive: Exactly. We should distinguish a demonstrated capability from the time required to produce an accepted report.

05 • Prospect finance operations lead: Could the success metric include all preparation and review time, rather than only the export duration?

06 • Account executive: Yes, if we agree consistent boundaries and measure them. We shouldn't exclude work merely because it occurs outside the product.

07 • Prospect finance operations lead: That would give our reporting stakeholders a more realistic basis for assessing the benefit.

08 • Account executive: I'll describe the export accurately and ask which remaining steps a pilot needs to examine.

09 • Prospect finance operations lead: Please keep any end-to-end saving as unverified until those steps are included.

10 • Account executive: Agreed. The proposal will separate what we demonstrated from what your workflow still needs to validate.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

A sales slide lists product features, but the prospect wants to reduce time spent preparing monthly reports.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: The relevant question is how the product supports your reporting workflow. I'll connect the demonstration to that task and show what would need to be tested before we claim a time saving.

Scenario 2 | Search results versus successful retrieval

A fictional prospect wants staff to find the correct procedure faster. A demonstration returns many search results, but no users have been tested for finding the correct current document. Explain the capability-outcome distinction and agree a success question.

Role A: You are the solutions consultant. Explain why result count is not the desired business outcome.

Role B: You are the prospect's service lead. Define the need as finding the correct current procedure, with timing still unmeasured.

Possible opening: Returning many results is a search capability; your outcome is finding the correct current procedure efficiently.

Success checks

- Distinguish product output from the prospect's intended outcome.
- Avoid claiming unmeasured accuracy or time savings.
- Agree a relevant success metric and stakeholder test.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call a larger result list better performance.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A prospect says a competitor is cheaper, but the quotes include different service levels and implementation support.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

objection - A stated concern or reason for not accepting a proposal.

competitor - An organization offering an alternative that serves similar customer needs.

differentiator - A characteristic that meaningfully distinguishes an offering from alternatives.

total cost - The combined costs included in a defined comparison, with assumptions stated.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Compare this wording: This option is more better.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of seven percentage points.
 - B. An increase of one percentage point.
 - C. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Cheaper quotes with different support

The lesson's prospect compares a lower-priced competitor quote with a proposal containing different service levels and implementation support.

01 • Prospect procurement manager: Your competitor is cheaper. Why should we pay more for your proposal?

02 • Account executive: Let's compare the same scope first. The quotes include different service levels and implementation support.

03 • Prospect procurement manager: Are you saying the competitor's offer is inferior, or simply that the prices cover different things?

04 • Account executive: The latter. We should identify the differences without inventing claims about their quality.

05 • Prospect procurement manager: Then show what is included and what our team would need to provide under each option.

06 • Account executive: Agreed. Total cost may involve internal effort as well as quoted fees, but that effort needs evidence.

07 • Prospect procurement manager: We may accept more internal work for a lower fee, depending on our available capacity.

08 • Account executive: That's a useful tradeoff to discuss. A differentiator matters only if it addresses your needs.

09 • Prospect procurement manager: Please compare both offers over the same service period and mark any unknown terms.

10 • Account executive: I will. We can address the price objection with a fair comparison rather than an unsupported superiority claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Lower entry fee, unconfirmed overage costs

Separate fictional case: a prospect compares two software offers for the same year; one has a lower base fee but its usage overage terms are not supplied.

01 • Prospect purchasing lead: The other offer has a lower base fee for the year. That makes its total cost lower, correct?

02 • Sales consultant: We can confirm the base-fee difference, but we don't have its overage terms or your expected usage.

03 • Prospect purchasing lead: So we need to distinguish entry price from the amount the same workload might actually cost.

04 • Sales consultant: Exactly. Both proposals should be compared using the same usage assumptions and service period.

05 • Prospect purchasing lead: Please don't assume the competitor's overages are expensive just because we haven't seen them.

06 • Sales consultant: Agreed. Unknown terms are unknown, not evidence against the competitor.

07 • Prospect purchasing lead: If our usage stays low, the lower base fee might suit us even with a different charging structure.

08 • Sales consultant: That's possible. We need the actual terms before describing the tradeoff accurately.

09 • Prospect purchasing lead: I'll obtain the missing pricing detail and confirm our expected workload with the service owner.

10 • Sales consultant: Then we can build a consistent comparison without presenting either untested scenario as guaranteed savings.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A faster launch with more client preparation

Separate fictional case: offer A states a two-week setup assuming client-prepared data; offer B states four weeks and includes data preparation. Data readiness is unconfirmed.

01 • Prospect project lead: Offer A promises two weeks, while offer B says four. Should we treat A as twice as fast?

02 • Account executive: Not for the whole workflow. A assumes client-prepared data, whereas B includes preparation in its stated scope.

03 • Prospect project lead: Our data readiness hasn't been confirmed, so A's setup period doesn't describe all the work we may need.

04 • Account executive: Correct. Compare the same starting condition and include responsibilities that sit with your team.

05 • Prospect project lead: Could the shorter supplier stage still be attractive if we can prepare the data ourselves?

06 • Account executive: Yes, conditionally. That would trade included preparation support for more internal responsibility.

07 • Prospect project lead: I don't want a competitive comparison that ignores the weaker side of either proposal.

08 • Account executive: Agreed. We'll show scope, assumptions, and timing boundaries without guessing the missing preparation effort.

09 • Prospect project lead: I'll ask our data owner to assess readiness before we choose based on those headline dates.

10 • Account executive: That will make the timing comparison meaningful and keep the decision tied to your actual capacity.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

A prospect says a competitor is cheaper, but the quotes include different service levels and implementation support.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: Could we compare the same scope and support assumptions? The quoted prices cover different packages. That will help us discuss total cost and fit without dismissing the other option.

Scenario 2 | A free pilot with different exit work

A fictional competitor offers a free pilot, while another proposal charges for setup. The competitor's data-export and exit-support terms are unknown, as are the prospect's likely exit needs. Compare the offers without implying that free means either best or deceptive.

Role A: You are the account executive. Ask for equivalent pilot scope and exit terms.

Role B: You are the prospect's evaluation lead. Explain what the pilot must test and what an orderly exit would require.

Possible opening: The pilot fee is one comparison point; could we also check setup responsibilities and exit support for both offers?

Success checks

- Use verified scope and pricing only.
- Treat missing competitor terms as unknown rather than unfavorable facts.
- Agree a consistent pilot and exit comparison.

Add a complication: A salesperson wants to invent hidden competitor fees to overcome the objection.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

A customer requests a 15% discount. The salesperson can discuss options but does not have authority to approve that reduction.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

discount - A reduction from a stated or usual price.

procurement - The process of sourcing, evaluating, and obtaining goods or services.

margin - The difference or allowance between values; in business, a measure of profitability.

approval path - The sequence of people or steps needed to authorize a decision.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Compare this wording: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
 - B. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.
 - B. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - C. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A fifteen-percent request needs approval

Separate fictional extension of the lesson: the customer requests a 15% discount on a proposal covering core setup and two onsite workshops. The salesperson cannot approve it. Remote workshops are an alternative to assess, but revised pricing and delivery approval remain pending.

01 • Customer procurement lead: We need a fifteen-percent discount. Can you approve it so we can move forward?

02 • Account executive: I can submit the request, but I cannot authorize that reduction. The current price remains unchanged.

03 • Customer procurement lead: What specific alternative could reduce the commitment without removing core setup?

04 • Account executive: If remote workshops meet your needs, I can seek a revised quote replacing the two onsite workshops while preserving core setup.

05 • Customer procurement lead: We could consider remote delivery, provided both workshops remain and our users can participate effectively.

06 • Account executive: Understood. I will request that scope, but I cannot promise either the saving or delivery approval.

07 • Customer procurement lead: Please compare the revised total and workshop arrangements, not just a discount percentage.

08 • Account executive: Agreed. We will assess the commercial impact, including margin, through the approval path.

09 • Customer procurement lead: Then submit both the fifteen-percent request and the remote-workshop alternative. Neither is accepted yet.

10 • Account executive: Correct. I will return with reviewed options and their conditions before changing the offer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A smaller first phase instead of an unapproved discount

Separate fictional case: a customer needs service for thirty users but asks whether starting with ten could reduce the initial commitment; pricing for the smaller scope is not approved.

01 • Customer project sponsor: Could we start with ten users instead of thirty to reduce the initial commitment?

02 • Account manager: We can assess that phased scope. I don't yet have an approved price for the smaller initial group.

03 • Customer project sponsor: Would the per-user price remain the same, or should we expect a different commercial arrangement?

04 • Account manager: That needs review. We shouldn't assume the thirty-user terms automatically apply to a ten-user phase.

05 • Customer project sponsor: Please also explain what onboarding support each phase would include, so we can compare the actual scope.

06 • Account manager: I will. A smaller commitment may change delivery planning as well as the quoted amount.

07 • Customer project sponsor: We could consider the phased option if it meets the first team's needs without committing the other twenty immediately.

08 • Account manager: Understood. I'll take that condition through the approval path and keep later expansion optional unless otherwise agreed.

09 • Customer project sponsor: Don't present our exploration as an accepted order for thirty users across two phases.

10 • Account manager: Agreed. I'll return with a clearly scoped proposal for your review before any commitment is recorded.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A payment-term request with no authority to concede

Separate fictional case: a buyer requests a longer payment period in place of a discount; the salesperson has not obtained finance approval for either change.

01 • Buyer procurement manager: If you cannot confirm a discount, could we discuss a longer payment period instead?

02 • Sales manager: Yes, as a request for review. I don't have finance approval to change the payment terms.

03 • Buyer procurement manager: Would that avoid affecting your margin, making it easier to approve than a price reduction?

04 • Sales manager: I can't assume its commercial impact or approval outcome. Finance needs to assess the actual proposal.

05 • Buyer procurement manager: Then please compare the requested payment arrangement with the current terms rather than treating it as costless.

06 • Sales manager: Agreed. Could you explain the timing you need and the reason, so the request is specific?

07 • Buyer procurement manager: I'll confirm our required payment period internally before you submit it for review.

08 • Sales manager: Thank you. We'll keep the existing proposal unchanged while the alternative is considered.

09 • Buyer procurement manager: And neither side should describe the alternative as agreed merely because we are discussing it.

10 • Sales manager: Correct. I'll communicate the reviewed decision and any conditions before revising the commercial offer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

A customer requests a 15% discount. The salesperson can discuss options but does not have authority to approve that reduction.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: I can take the request through our approval process. Could we clarify the scope and commercial terms you are proposing? I do not want to promise a discount before it is authorized.

Scenario 2 | A discount tied to an unconfirmed reference call

A fictional customer offers to provide a reference call in exchange for a discount. Neither the customer's reference permission nor the supplier's discount approval is confirmed. Discuss the proposal without treating either side's offer as authorized.

Role A: You are the salesperson. Explain the required commercial review and ask about reference approval.

Role B: You are the customer contact. Clarify that you must obtain internal permission before offering a reference.

Possible opening: We can discuss the proposal, but both the discount and the reference participation need the appropriate approvals.

Success checks

- Keep both approvals explicitly pending.
- Describe the proposed exchange without promising acceptance.
- Agree who confirms each condition before terms change.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to record the reference as committed to justify the discount request.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Enterprise Buying Committees

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A contact is enthusiastic about a proposal but has not explained who controls the budget or approves the purchase.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

champion - A contact inside a customer organization who actively supports a proposed solution.

economic buyer - The person with authority over the budget or financial approval for a purchase.

buying committee - The people who influence or approve an organization's purchase decision.

forecast category - A defined label indicating the expected likelihood or stage of a sales opportunity.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - B. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - C. Could you confirm when starts the review?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - B. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - C. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An enthusiastic contact is not a confirmed economic buyer

The lesson's contact supports the proposal but has not identified budget control or purchase approval responsibilities.

01 • Account executive: You're enthusiastic about the proposal. Could you clarify who controls the budget and who approves a purchase?

02 • Customer project contact: I haven't explained that buying process yet. My support doesn't mean I can authorize the expenditure.

03 • Account executive: Understood. We should distinguish a potential champion from the economic buyer rather than assume you hold both roles.

04 • Customer project contact: Could you explain economic buyer in ordinary language so I can identify the right colleague?

05 • Account executive: The person with relevant budget decision authority. We need your actual process, not a title-based guess.

06 • Customer project contact: I'll check which colleagues participate and whether separate approvals are needed for the proposed scope.

07 • Account executive: Thank you. Would a joint discussion be appropriate once you confirm the buying committee?

08 • Customer project contact: Possibly. Let me confirm their roles before offering meeting dates or claiming they support the proposal.

09 • Account executive: I'll keep the forecast category based on what is known, not on enthusiasm alone.

10 • Customer project contact: Good. I'll return with the decision roles and any remaining questions about the purchasing route.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Technical approval leaves budget authority unresolved

Separate fictional case: a prospect's IT reviewer has found no technical objection, but budget ownership and procurement approval are unconfirmed.

01 • Sales director: Your IT reviewer found no technical objection. Could you clarify which purchase decisions remain beyond that review?

02 • Prospect program lead: Budget ownership and procurement approval are still unconfirmed. The technical review doesn't settle them.

03 • Sales director: Then we should not describe the buying committee as fully aligned or the purchase as approved.

04 • Prospect program lead: Correct. Could you help me distinguish the questions we need to ask internally?

05 • Sales director: Ask who authorizes the budget, who manages procurement, and which decision each person needs to make.

06 • Prospect program lead: I'll verify those roles rather than infer authority from who attended the technical demonstration.

07 • Sales director: Good. A technical reviewer can influence the decision without being the economic buyer.

08 • Prospect program lead: Once the roles are clear, we can discuss whether another meeting is useful and who should join.

09 • Sales director: I'll record the completed technical review separately from the unresolved commercial approval path.

10 • Prospect program lead: That accurately reflects our position and avoids putting a commitment into the forecast that we haven't made.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A champion changes roles before the decision

Separate fictional case: an internal champion moves to another department; the successor's interest and budget authority have not been confirmed.

01 • Account manager: Our champion has moved departments. Could you clarify who now owns the business need behind this proposal?

02 • Customer coordinator: A successor is named, but I haven't confirmed their priorities or budget authority yet.

03 • Account manager: Then we shouldn't assume the previous champion's support transfers automatically to the new contact.

04 • Customer coordinator: Agreed. The successor may need a fresh explanation of the problem and the decision under consideration.

05 • Account manager: Could you ask whether they are the right person to review the use case and identify the buying committee?

06 • Customer coordinator: Yes. I'll confirm their role before promising that they can approve the purchase.

07 • Account manager: Thank you. I'll keep the economic buyer and current sponsorship marked unconfirmed in our opportunity record.

08 • Customer coordinator: Would you send a concise recap so I can introduce the discussion without presenting it as an approved project?

09 • Account manager: Certainly. It will distinguish prior interest from the decisions still needed under the new ownership.

10 • Customer coordinator: Then I'll arrange the appropriate introduction once the successor's role and availability are established.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Enterprise Buying Committees

A contact is enthusiastic about a proposal but has not explained who controls the budget or approves the purchase.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Who else needs to evaluate the proposal, and how is the budget approved? I'd like to understand the decision process so we can provide the right information to each participant.

Scenario 2 | Branch and parent-company approval roles are unclear

A fictional branch contact wants to buy a service, but says the parent company may control software spending. Neither party's approval role is confirmed. Clarify the buying committee without guessing from organizational seniority.

Role A: You are the account executive. Ask who owns the budget and which approvals apply to this purchase.

Role B: You are the branch operations contact. Explain the uncertainty and identify the internal person who can clarify it.

Possible opening: Could you confirm whether this purchase is decided at the branch or requires parent-company approval?

Success checks

- Separate job title from confirmed purchase authority.
- Identify the unresolved budget and approval questions.
- Agree a clarification contact before changing the forecast category.

Add a complication: A salesperson assumes the branch director can approve everything because of their title.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Negotiation and Contract Redlines

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A customer returns contract wording on liability and asks the salesperson to accept it immediately.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

redline - A version of a document showing proposed additions, deletions, or changes.

liability - Legal responsibility or an obligation; in accounting, an amount or duty owed.

indemnity - A contractual obligation to compensate for specified losses, subject to its terms and applicable law.

commercial term - A business condition of an agreement, such as price, quantity, or payment timing.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - B. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - C. Send it no later than Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - B. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - C. Could you confirm that the review is important?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Route the liability redline for authorized review

The lesson's customer returns liability wording and requests immediate acceptance from the salesperson.

01 • Customer procurement lead: We've returned our liability wording. Please accept it now so the contract discussion can move on.

02 • Account executive: Could you send the marked version and identify the changed clauses? I need to route them for authorized review.

03 • Customer procurement lead: Can't you simply agree? These are the terms our team prefers to use.

04 • Account executive: I can't accept liability changes on behalf of the legal reviewer. Your preference doesn't establish our approval.

05 • Customer procurement lead: What can you do now to keep the review moving without promising an immediate decision?

06 • Account executive: I'll submit the redline with your stated concern and ask the reviewer to confirm realistic response timing.

07 • Customer procurement lead: Please distinguish this legal wording from the commercial terms we're discussing separately.

08 • Account executive: Agreed. I'll keep the review questions separate and avoid interpreting indemnity or liability provisions myself.

09 • Customer procurement lead: I'll send the tracked version and the reason for the requested change through our contract channel.

10 • Account executive: Thank you. I'll confirm routing and report the authorized response, without treating receipt as acceptance.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Two contract versions in the negotiation

Separate fictional case: a buyer's email refers to version four, but its attachment is version three; the salesperson has no confirmed final redline.

01 • Sales contract coordinator: Could you confirm the intended contract version? Your email names version four, while the attachment is labeled version three.

02 • Buyer contract manager: I'll check before you route it. I don't want your reviewer assessing an outdated redline.

03 • Sales contract coordinator: Please send the intended version with changes visible so the reviewer can identify the actual request.

04 • Buyer contract manager: Would it help if I simply rename this attachment version four to match the email?

05 • Sales contract coordinator: Only if its contents are verified as the correct version. A new filename alone doesn't resolve the mismatch.

06 • Buyer contract manager: Understood. I'll compare the document with our internal record and confirm which text is current.

07 • Sales contract coordinator: Thank you. I'll hold the new review submission rather than guess which commercial or legal terms you intended.

08 • Buyer contract manager: I'll also identify whether the changes concern pricing, liability, or other clauses, without claiming your acceptance.

09 • Sales contract coordinator: That will help routing. Please confirm the expected send time after verifying the file.

10 • Buyer contract manager: I will. We'll settle the version question before asking anyone to approve its contents.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A commercial request mixed with an indemnity change

Separate fictional case: a customer returns a proposal requesting quarterly billing and revised indemnity wording; neither change has been approved by the supplier.

01 • Customer commercial manager: Our response requests quarterly billing and a revised indemnity clause. Could you confirm both today?

02 • Account manager: I can route both requests, but they require the appropriate commercial and legal review rather than one informal acceptance.

03 • Customer commercial manager: What information would make each request actionable for the relevant reviewer?

04 • Account manager: Please provide the proposed billing arrangement and the marked contract wording, with your reasons for each change.

05 • Customer commercial manager: Could you approve billing now while leaving the indemnity language for later?

06 • Account manager: I haven't obtained billing approval either. I'll ask the commercial owner to assess it separately.

07 • Customer commercial manager: Understood. We don't need you to interpret the legal clause; we need a clear review route.

08 • Account manager: Exactly. I'll request response timing from each owner and tell you if the timelines differ.

09 • Customer commercial manager: I'll send the two requests clearly separated so the legal question doesn't obscure the billing requirement.

10 • Account manager: Thank you. I'll confirm submission and keep both decisions pending until the authorized responses arrive.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Negotiation and Contract Redlines

A customer returns contract wording on liability and asks the salesperson to accept it immediately.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: I'll send the proposed wording to the appropriate legal and commercial reviewers. Could you explain the business concern behind the change so they can assess it in context?

Scenario 2 | An unmarked replacement clause

A fictional customer pastes a replacement contract paragraph into an email without identifying the original clause or document version. The salesperson cannot assess its legal effect. Request a reviewable redline and realistic routing information.

Role A: You are the salesperson. Ask for the document version, clause reference, and marked change.

Role B: You are the customer's contract coordinator. Clarify what you can supply and when you can confirm availability.

Possible opening: Could you send the replacement wording against the intended contract version so our reviewer can assess the change?

Success checks

- Request a specific reviewable document and clause reference.
- Avoid interpreting or accepting legal wording without authority.
- Agree routing and a realistic timing check rather than a guaranteed approval.

Add a complication: The customer asks you to reply accepted before supplying the missing context.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Partnerships and Channel Development

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

A potential channel partner requests exclusivity but has not specified territory, activities, or expected contribution.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

channel partner - An organization that helps market, sell, deliver, or support another organization's offering.

exclusivity - An arrangement limiting specified rights or activities to one party for an agreed scope.

pipeline - A sequence of stages through which data, work, or sales opportunities move.

enablement - Resources and preparation that help a team perform a role effectively.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Compare this wording: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
 - B. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.
 - B. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - C. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Exclusivity needs a defined scope

The lesson's potential channel partner requests exclusivity without specifying territory, activities, or expected contribution.

01 • Potential channel partner: We would like exclusivity before investing time in this partnership. Can you agree in principle?

02 • Partnership manager: We can discuss the request, but territory, activities, and expected contribution haven't been defined.

03 • Potential channel partner: Could we leave those details for later and start with a broad exclusivity commitment?

04 • Partnership manager: That would commit us before the scope is clear. We need a bounded proposal and authorized review.

05 • Potential channel partner: What could we explore while those conditions are being developed?

06 • Partnership manager: A nonexclusive discovery phase or a limited proposal, with any activities and enablement support explicitly agreed.

07 • Potential channel partner: We would need to understand what support is available before estimating our pipeline contribution.

08 • Partnership manager: Agreed. We should compare commitments on both sides rather than assume an exclusivity request creates qualified opportunities.

09 • Potential channel partner: I'll clarify the territory and activities we want to discuss, without treating this conversation as an agreement.

10 • Partnership manager: I'll assess the support requirements and approval route, then return with conditions for a substantive negotiation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Training support before a reseller launch

Separate fictional case: a prospective reseller requests product training for twenty staff before signing an agreement; training capacity and commercial terms are not confirmed.

01 • Prospective reseller lead: Could you train twenty of our staff before we sign? It would help us prepare the channel launch.

02 • Channel development manager: We can assess enablement support, but training capacity and the commercial arrangement are not yet confirmed.

03 • Prospective reseller lead: Would one introductory session be possible while we discuss a larger training program?

04 • Channel development manager: That's a bounded option to review, with audience, purpose, and scheduling conditions made explicit.

05 • Prospective reseller lead: We don't want an introduction presented as certification or permission to make technical commitments to customers.

06 • Channel development manager: Agreed. The session's scope should distinguish product orientation from any later qualification or authorization.

07 • Prospective reseller lead: Please explain what preparation our staff would need and whether the session depends on an agreement.

08 • Channel development manager: I'll confirm those conditions through the relevant owners rather than invent a training policy here.

09 • Prospective reseller lead: Then we'll hold off announcing a launch date until the partnership and support arrangements are clearer.

10 • Channel development manager: Thank you. I'll bring a reviewed introductory option without promising the full twenty-person program.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A shared lead needs agreed responsibilities

Separate fictional case: two potential partners discuss a jointly identified prospect; neither has agreed customer-contact ownership or pipeline attribution.

01 • Partner account lead: We both identified this prospect. Could we agree who contacts them before we make separate approaches?

02 • Channel manager: Yes. Customer-contact ownership and pipeline attribution are still open, so neither team should assume an exclusive claim.

03 • Partner account lead: We can lead the introduction if your team supports the product discussion, subject to an agreed arrangement.

04 • Channel manager: That is a possible division of work. We need to clarify support, information sharing, and each team's authority.

05 • Partner account lead: Would leading the introduction automatically give us ownership of all later opportunities at the account?

06 • Channel manager: We haven't agreed that. Keep this proposed arrangement bounded to the specific prospect discussion.

07 • Partner account lead: Understood. Let's negotiate this initial activity rather than create account-wide exclusivity by implication.

08 • Channel manager: Agreed. I'll seek the relevant approval and confirm what customer information can be shared through our process.

09 • Partner account lead: I'll pause outreach until we confirm the contact plan, so the customer doesn't receive conflicting approaches.

10 • Channel manager: Then we can proceed with clear responsibilities and record the pipeline status without duplicate ownership claims.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Partnerships and Channel Development

A potential channel partner requests exclusivity but has not specified territory, activities, or expected contribution.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: Could we define the territory, responsibilities, and expected contribution first? Those details are necessary for the team to evaluate whether an exclusive arrangement would make sense.

Scenario 2 | A partner requests a guaranteed lead quota

A fictional prospective channel partner asks for ten qualified leads per month in return for attending enablement sessions. No lead volume is forecast or approved. Discuss a bounded alternative without guaranteeing pipeline.

Role A: You are the channel manager. Explain that training participation does not establish a guaranteed lead allocation.

Role B: You are the prospective partner lead. Explore a reviewable activity plan and how progress might be assessed.

Possible opening: We can discuss an activity plan, but we cannot treat ten qualified leads per month as a confirmed commitment.

Success checks

- Keep unverified lead volume out of commitments.
- Negotiate concrete activities and review conditions.
- Distinguish a proposed arrangement from an approved public announcement.

Add a complication: The partner wants the guarantee included in a launch announcement before agreement.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A deal is forecast to close this month, but procurement has not started and the customer has given no confirmed date.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

CRM - Customer relationship management: processes and systems used to manage customer information and interactions.

pipeline - A sequence of stages through which data, work, or sales opportunities move.

close date - The expected date on which a sales transaction will be completed.

commit - A sales forecast category indicating an expected close under the organization's defined criteria.

slippage - Movement of an expected completion or sales close date to a later time.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A close date without customer confirmation

The lesson's deal is forecast to close this month, but procurement has not begun and the customer has given no confirmed date.

01 • Sales manager: The CRM shows a close date this month. What customer evidence supports that date?

02 • Account executive: Procurement hasn't started, and the customer hasn't confirmed a date. The entry reflects our expectation, not their commitment.

03 • Sales manager: Then we should distinguish the internal target from a verified step in the buying process.

04 • Account executive: Agreed. I shouldn't describe the deal as commit solely because the calendar contains a close date.

05 • Sales manager: What should change in the pipeline review while those dependencies remain unresolved?

06 • Account executive: I'll state the missing procurement step and date confirmation, then review the forecast category under our actual definitions.

07 • Sales manager: Good. Don't invent a later customer date simply to move the uncertainty into another month.

08 • Account executive: I'll record the uncertainty and ask the customer about the remaining process and realistic timing.

09 • Sales manager: That gives us evidence to assess possible slippage without claiming the deal is lost or guaranteed.

10 • Account executive: I'll update the record with confirmed information and keep assumptions visibly separate from customer statements.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A verbal preference is not a signed order

Separate fictional case: a prospect says the supplier is its preferred option, but contract review and signature authority remain unconfirmed.

01 • Account executive: The prospect called us their preferred option. I was going to mark the opportunity as effectively closed.

02 • Pipeline reviewer: Preference is positive evidence, but contract review and signature authority remain unconfirmed in the record.

03 • Account executive: Then I should preserve the customer's words without translating them into a purchase commitment.

04 • Pipeline reviewer: Exactly. The CRM should distinguish expressed preference from the steps required for an actual order.

05 • Account executive: Could I keep the current close date as a target while noting that the customer hasn't confirmed it?

06 • Pipeline reviewer: Use the applicable forecast definitions and label its basis clearly. Don't imply a confirmed customer date.

07 • Account executive: I'll ask about the outstanding review and authorized signatory rather than assume our contact can sign.

08 • Pipeline reviewer: Good. A forecast category should reflect the relevant evidence, not simply the optimism of the latest conversation.

09 • Account executive: I'll update the next action and open dependencies, with the preference statement attributed to the prospect.

10 • Pipeline reviewer: That makes the opportunity easier to assess without overstating either certainty or risk.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Two records may describe one opportunity

Separate fictional case: a CRM pipeline contains two records for the same prospect discussion, each with the same proposed value; ownership and duplication have not yet been reconciled.

01 • Revenue operations analyst: These two CRM records appear to describe the same prospect discussion, each carrying the full proposed value.

02 • Sales team lead: Can we include both until ownership is settled, since two account representatives are involved?

03 • Revenue operations analyst: That may double-count one opportunity. Representative involvement doesn't establish two separate purchases.

04 • Sales team lead: Then we need to verify whether the records concern distinct scopes or an actual duplicate.

05 • Revenue operations analyst: Exactly. We shouldn't delete or merge them blindly, but the possible duplication must be visible in the forecast.

06 • Sales team lead: I'll ask both owners to confirm the customer need, scope, and current buying-process evidence.

07 • Revenue operations analyst: Good. The pipeline total should not present an unresolved duplicate as confirmed additional value.

08 • Sales team lead: And we should preserve the relevant history when the records are reconciled under our CRM process.

09 • Revenue operations analyst: Agreed. I'll flag the counting issue and keep the correction traceable rather than silently changing the total.

10 • Sales team lead: I'll coordinate the ownership check and return with evidence of one opportunity or two genuinely distinct scopes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

A deal is forecast to close this month, but procurement has not started and the customer has given no confirmed date.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The current close date is an assumption. Procurement has not started, and the customer has not confirmed timing. I'll update the forecast explanation and identify the next evidence needed.

Scenario 2 | A procurement meeting was rescheduled

A fictional prospect moved its procurement meeting from this week to next week. The deal's close date was never confirmed by the customer. Discuss the forecast impact without assuming either inevitable slippage or no effect.

Role A: You are the account executive. State the meeting change and the unconfirmed close date.

Role B: You are the sales manager. Ask which dependencies need checking before revising the forecast.

Possible opening: The procurement meeting moved to next week, but we still do not have a customer-confirmed close date.

Success checks

- Separate a scheduled meeting from a purchase commitment.
- Explain possible timing impact without presenting it as certain.
- Agree the customer clarification needed for the forecast update.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the deal guaranteed for this month because the meeting remains on the calendar.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Discovery and Qualification

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: The relevant question is how the product supports your reporting workflow. I'll connect the demonstration to that task and show what would need to be tested before we claim a time saving.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

B: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

C: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

Check 2: B - An increase of one percentage point.

A: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

B: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

C: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

Model response: Could we compare the same scope and support assumptions? The quoted prices cover different packages. That will help us discuss total cost and fit without dismissing the other option.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

B: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

C: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

Check 2: A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

B: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

C: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

Model response: I can take the request through our approval process. Could we clarify the scope and commercial terms you are proposing? I do not want to promise a discount before it is authorized.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Enterprise Buying Committees

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: A - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

B: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

C: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

Check 2: C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

B: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

C: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

Model response: Who else needs to evaluate the proposal, and how is the budget approved? I'd like to understand the decision process so we can provide the right information to each participant.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Negotiation and Contract Redlines

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: C - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

B: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

C: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

Check 2: B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

B: The requested action and information are explicit.

C: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

Model response: I'll send the proposed wording to the appropriate legal and commercial reviewers. Could you explain the business concern behind the change so they can assess it in context?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Partnerships and Channel Development

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

B: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

C: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

Check 2: A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

B: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

C: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

Model response: Could we define the territory, responsibilities, and expected contribution first? Those details are necessary for the team to evaluate whether an exclusive arrangement would make sense.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: The current close date is an assumption. Procurement has not started, and the customer has not confirmed timing. I'll update the forecast explanation and identify the next evidence needed.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Sales and Business Development English

Professional audience: account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Discovery and Qualification

Original fictional case: A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: discovery: The process of learning needs or facts; in litigation, formal exchange of relevant information. / qualification: Documented demonstration that an item, process, or person meets defined requirements for a purpose. / pain point: A specific difficulty experienced by a customer or user. / buying process: The steps an organization follows to evaluate, approve, and make a purchase.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level